

PRE-CLASS READING 5 OF 5

Generative AI at DBS: an AI-powered transformation

DBS Bank (2023). "DBS' AI-Powered Digital Transformation" — interview with Jimmy Ng, Group CIO (orig. published by Wachsman, Aug 2023).

ASSIGNED READING

Full article — the Jimmy Ng Q&A interview ~15 min

» ~15 min

Note on currency. Figures here are 2022–23 (600+ models, 300 use cases, ~SGD 180M value in 2022, GenAI still 'early days'). By 2024–25 DBS reports 2,000+ models and 400+ use cases, and its internal DBS-GPT assistant has reached 25,000+ employees. Read for the architecture and the reasoning, not the running totals.

KEY TAKEAWAY

DBS did not buy 'an AI.' Over a decade it built the stack — cloud + APIs, the ADA data platform, the ALAN deployment layer, and the P-U-R-E governance framework — so that AI could be industrialised across 300+ use cases. Generative AI then sits on top of that foundation, which is why the bank could move on it quickly and safely.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR THIS COURSE

DBS is the real-world spine of Class 2: capsule C1 (map the stack) and C2 (build-vs-buy) map directly onto its layers, and it anchors the economics thread (SGD 180M rising toward a projected SGD 1bn). It also rhymes with Class 1's Moderna case — both are 'an organisation builds an AI capability,' but where Moderna democratised use across people, DBS built the stack underneath.

Feeds Class 2: C1 (map the stack) • C2 (build-vs-buy) • the economics thread.

MAIN POINTS

The turnaround, and three pillars

- **From laggard to leader.** In 2009 DBS had the lowest customer-satisfaction scores of any Singapore bank; a decade later it is repeatedly named the world's best digital bank.
- **Three pillars.** Be 'digital to the core' (cloud + open source + APIs + microservices, in-house tech), embed in the customer journey, and operate like a start-up. Starting early (2014) put 'daylight' between DBS and its peers.

The stack they built

- **ADA — Advancing DBS with AI.** An internal, self-service platform that is the single 'source of truth' for data governance, discoverability, quality and security. (The data layer.)
- **ALAN.** An award-winning AI protocol and knowledge repository for deploying models at scale and speed. (The serving / MLOps layer.) Together, ADA + ALAN are a build-and-deploy pipeline.

What it produced

- **Scale.** 600+ AI/ML models across 300 use cases; 45 million hyper-personalised 'nudges' sent monthly to 5 million customers.
- **Speed to value.** 'DBS Quick Finance' — one minute to apply, one second to approve (SME financing up to SGD 300k); SME credit early-warning flagged 95% of non-performing loans ~3 months ahead, and averted risk for 80% of those flagged.
- **Economics.** SGD 180M of measured value in 2022 (SGD 150M revenue uplift + SGD 30M cost avoidance / productivity), with AI/ML projected to contribute SGD 1bn over five years.

Responsible AI, and people

- **P-U-R-E.** Every data and AI use case must be Purposeful, Unsurprising, Respectful and Explainable before deployment, with controlled, monitored access. DBS works closely with the Monetary Authority of Singapore (MAS) and the IMDA.
- **Reskilling.** First Singapore bank (2017) to run a professional-conversion programme; 8,000+ employees upskilled — the human layer of adoption.

GenAI, and the Asia view (as of 2023)

- **GenAI is early.** The modern stack built since 2014 lets DBS explore GenAI safely; the first focus is employee productivity.
- **Asia is moving fast.** APAC is among the fastest-growing AI regions; China and India are well-placed on talent, and Singapore's National AI Strategy targets 2030 — context worth holding for our cohort.

READING FOCUS QUESTIONS — bring your answers to class

There are no wrong answers — these surface how you think, not what you recall.

1. DBS built ADA (data) and P-U-R-E (governance) in-house but rents its models. For an organisation you know, which layers would you own versus rent — and why?
2. P-U-R-E asks every use case to be Purposeful, Unsurprising, Respectful, Explainable. Pick an AI use case in your industry: which of the four is hardest to satisfy, and why?
3. DBS's edge wasn't a model others lacked — it was a decade of data and platform work. In your industry, what is the equivalent moat a rival couldn't copy just by calling the same API?

SOURCE LINKS

Article • <https://www.dbs.com/artificial-intelligence-machine-learning/artificial-intelligence/dbs-ai-powered-digital-transformation.html>

Related — Piyush Gupta on DBS' AI & data • <https://www.dbs.com/artificial-intelligence-machine-learning/artificial-intelligence/piyush-gupta-counting-on-dbs-ai-and-data-capabilities-to-pull-ahead.html>

Related — Responsible AI in banking • <https://www.dbs.com/artificial-intelligence-machine-learning/artificial-intelligence/responsible-ai-in-banking-gaining-a-competitive-edge.html>

CAVEATS

- 1. This summarises DBS's public article and is safe to read ahead. The Harvard Business School case, 'DBS' AI Journey' (625-053), is a separate, copyrighted document we brief live in class — see the case-study handout; you do not need the case beforehand.
- 2. This summary was generated and fact-checked using Anthropic models against the DBS article. Figures are point-in-time (2022–23) and have since grown. Flag anything that looks wrong.